

You should also get a head start on holiday baking. Cookies, pies, and all sorts of sweet treats almost always freeze well, and you won't have to spend every waking moment in the kitchen preparing food for your special guests. Plus, if you start early enough, you have the luxury of making goodies as their ingredients go on sale, instead of waiting until the last minute and buying everything at full price.

4. BE SMART ABOUT DECOR

You don't have to spend money on cheaply made decor items that fall apart after the first year you use them. Not when there are so many cute and gorgeous decorating projects on Pinterest anyway! You don't have to be particularly crafty to do them either. Just follow a few simple instructions and have a glue gun close by.

Here are some quick ideas for decor that makes a big impact on your home, not your wallet:

- Print out a cute printable and buy a cheap frame from the dollar or craft store.
- Use fabric scraps on a Styrofoam cone shape to create a pretty Christmas tree.
- Spray paint pinecones and create your own holiday mantle display with lights and a mini village made out of scrapbook paper covered cardboard.
- Put your own touch on a homemade wreath. Buy a few sprigs of greenery, holly berries, and add a festive bow.

You can also scout out deep Christmas discounts for store-bought items if you prefer. Michaels and Hobby Lobby usually have the best sales, and mark down their decor pieces, artificial trees, and other glittering baubles at 50% off during December. After Christmas it goes down to 70%, but the earlier you can go, the better. Last year, Michaels was only down to a few shelves of Christmas supplies *two* days after the holiday!